Ace Lacewing: Bug Detective

By David Biedrzycki

It was a night like any other night in the city. Hot and sticky. Great weather if you're a bug. Everyone's a bug in Motham City. Some good, some bad. Bad bugs are my business. I was in my office eating some aphid lo mein when the phone buzzed. I answered it. "Ace Lacewing, Bug Detective."

INTRODUCTION

He's tall, he's handsome and he has two antennae. He's Ace Lacewing, Bug Detective by David Biedrzycki

It was Mayor Buzzbee. Behind him it sounded like a beehive of activity. Actually, it **was** a beehive. "What's the buzz?"

MAYOR: Ace! I'm at the Hive Rise with Princess Pollen. Queenie Bee's been kidnapped. Get over here now!

Queenie Bee kidnapped? Who would do a thing like that? Everyone loved Queenie and her sister Princess Pollen. The Hive Rise Honey Company made the best

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honey in town. Maybe someone thought it was **too** good . . . I was just about to fly out the door when I saw her standing there, like a moth drawn to a flame. The lovely rare butterfly, Doctor Xerces Blue. Not the kind of doctor who takes your tonsils out. The kind of doctor who studies bugs – dead bugs.

XERCES: Oh, Acie. How about dinner at my place tonight? Just you and me. I'm making your favorite – aphids a la mode.

"The aphids will have to stew, sweetheart. Queenie Bee's in a honey of a jam!" . . . Downtown the traffic was crawling.

SGT ZITO: Hey, Ace!

It was Sergeant Zito, a mosquito. And a cop. I've known him ever since we were pupae at the same school. "Whadda ya know, Zito?"

SGT ZITO: We have a couple of witnesses, Ace. But none of them are talking except this little maggot.

MAGGOT: I saw the whole thing! I was crawling around minding my own business when all of a sudden I heard all this screamin'. I looked up and I saw 'em right outside the Hive Rise – a couple of hooded bugs running off with

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Queenie Bee!

"Which way did they go?" . . . I should have known better than to ask directions from a bug with no arms or legs. I told Zito to start rounding up suspects. I looked around . . . and noticed a suspicious trail of honey leading away from the crime scene. I followed it.

At the corner of Tomato and Vine, I stopped in my tracks. The honey trail led to the Beetle Zoo. Lacewings have lost their heads to beetles. But I was on a case. It was Hive Rise Honey, all right. Still warm. I heard a noise, stood up, and froze!

Someone had let the tiger beetle out of his cage, and this guy didn't want to play! He wanted to eat. I did the only thing a bug detective worth his wings would do. I screamed and ran . . . smack into a wall. Ahhh, it could have been worse. It could have been a windshield on the interstate. [When I came to] I was lying in a corner of the police station. A bunch of handcuffed roaches and other pests were waiting to be questioned. Everyone had an alibi. The roaches said of course they ran from the scene of the crime – it was their nature to scatter when the lights go on.

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Before we could question the cicada, he molted and flew out the window. Twig couldn't have run anywhere. He was a walking stick. We brought in Smooch, the assassin bug. No one wanted to get near his kisser. We decided to call it a night.

DRONE BEE: Psssssst! Hey, Lacewing. I know who's got Queenie and why.

ACE: Who are you?

DRONE BEE: A drone who knows the truth. But there are too many eyes and too many antennae around here. Let's go someplace we can talk in private . . .

We never got the chance. It happened quick as a cricket – a drive-by gassing. "Hit the dirt!" But it was too late for the bee. I couldn't make out the driver, but the other one was no doubt a bombardier beetle. I could tell by the smell. I wondered if he had a license to pass gas. I checked the bee. He wasn't moving, but he was trying to say something. I lowered my ear to his mouth . . . . Al the Drone.

SGT ZITO: Al the Drone? Oh no, not Al the Drone! Please don't let it be Al the Drone. Anybody but Al the Drone . . . Who's Al the Drone?

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Al the Drone owns Drone HoneyWorks. Some bugs say he has his sticky little mandibles in more than just honey. I think we should pay Mr. Drone a visit. Xerces worked on the bee as Zito and I took off across town.

Outside Drone HoneyWorks, the smell of honey hung thicker in the air than ants on a popsicle stick. Savage mantises kept guard. The back gate of the Beetle Zoo was right across the street. And the trail of honey led from the zoo to the HoneyWorks! We needed a way in. But how?

Two dung beetles were making their way up the street, rolling their dung ball and collecting trash. They rolled up next to us. The dung beetles were too busy to notice us.

ACE: *(to Zito)* "You thinkin' what I'm thinkin'?"

SGT ZITO: Oh no, Ace, not the dung.

"Hold your breath!" We leapt onto the dung ball and rolled right past a mantis into the HoneyWorks. I peered in a window. What I saw made my antennae quiver. In the shadows I saw someone tied up and blindfolded. It looked like Queenie. She sure wasn't getting the royal treatment here.

SGT ZITO: Uh . . . . Ace? We got company . . .

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One of the mantises had followed our dung prints. He didn't look too happy. Neither were we when he tied us up and carried us inside.

Inside, the aroma of honey and pollen was sickeningly sweet. I've been in hives before. You can tell a good hive by the buzz of the bees. The buzz in here was not good. The mantis looked as if he were in a trance as he toted us past rows and rows of honeycomb. Standing in the shadows was Al the Drone . . . [or was it?]

MANTIS: Hey, boss. Look what I found snoopin' around outside.

UNIDENTIFIED DRONE: Well, well, if it ain't the little lacewing and his blood-sucking friend.

ACE: I know you got Queenie here, Drone. You'll never get away with it!

UNIDENTIFIED DRONE: Funny, that's the same thing Queenie said to me, and look where she is now.

I couldn't believe my eyes. Queenie was stuffed into a honeycomb, alive but not for long. If Queenie was holding her breath in the honeycomb, then who was tied up in the next room? Who was the mystery bug in the shadows? And why did the Drone smell of pollen? . . . .

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Pollen! That was it! The clues clicked together in my head.

UNIDENTIFIED DRONE: Any last words, Lacewing?

"Yeah. Since when do **drones** gather pollen?" The whole place went quiet.

PRINCESS POLLEN: Ha, you're clever, Lacewing. Clever, clever, clever.

SGT ZITO: P-p-princess P-pollen?!

PRINCESS POLLEN: In the exoskeleton! . . . I'm sick of just being princess!! I want to be QUEEN! It's always Queenie Bee this and Queenie Bee that. I'll never have my own hive with her around. So I'm making it look like sleazy Al the Drone got rid of her. You guessed it, Lacewing – that's him tied up in the back room. With Queenie and Drone HoneyWorks gone, I'll be queen of the town. You're in a rather sticky situation, Lacewing, so see ya, wouldn't wanna **bee** ya!

Princess Pollen made her way to the door. She signaled the mantises to seal us in the honeycombs. I had to think fast. Something fluttered overhead, so I shouted the only thing that makes a mantis run for cover. "BAT!!!"

The mantis threw us high in the air. We soared helplessly until whatever was flying above grabbed us . . .It

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wasn't a bat. It was Xerces. She had rounded up every cop from here to Termite Heights and brought them to the HoneyWorks, saving my wings again.

Dawn was emerging like a monarch from a chrysalis when Xerces and I sat down for a plate of aphids a la mode. "Here's to blue wings and my favorite things."

And the city of Motham fluttered awake behind her.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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